

Inspirations

The works this chapter of the practice is in conversation with. September 2026.

HOW TO READ THIS

This is a reading and looking list rather than an image book. No artwork is reproduced here. Every entry names the artist, the work and the reason it is held, and points to where the work can be seen properly. That decision is partly about copyright and partly about accuracy, since a reproduction at this scale would misrepresent every piece on the list.

The list is organised by what each work refuses to do, which turns out to be more useful than organising by medium or period. A refusal is portable. A technique often is not.

Entries are drawn from the project's own artist reference, which holds one historical, one contemporary and one emerging artist for each of fifty-six weeks. What follows is a selection rather than the whole of it.

Dates, exhibition histories and gallery representation change. Anything load-bearing should be checked against the source before it is quoted or carried into an application.

ONE

Work that refuses to be special

The argument for a fixed format, a monthly rhythm, and the unremarkable as sufficient subject.

Giorgio Morandi (1890–1964)

The studio-table still lifes, four decades

The same small collection of bottles, jars and boxes, slightly rearranged, in shifting light, for forty years. The most radical refusal of specialness available: nothing new is required, and the same ordinary things attended to with complete fidelity are inexhaustible. The historical authority for the studies series.

Martine Syms (b. 1988)

Video and installation work

Black everyday life treated as archive, as theory and as art. Vernacular speech, casual gesture, domestic ritual. The insistence that the ordinary is already doing the work and does not need elevating before it can be looked at.

Zoe Williams (b. 1991)

Paintings of interiors, kitchenware, fabric and domestic objects

Morandi's loving fidelity brought to a Black British domestic interior, insisting that this specific ordinariness is as worthy of sustained attention as any canonical subject. London-based; represented by Pilar Corrias.

TWO

Work that refuses to be kept

The direct challenge to a practice that sells objects.

Felix Gonzalez-Torres (1957–1996)

The candy pile works

The weight of the candy equals the weight of a partner who died of AIDS. The work gives itself away. It cannot be possessed, only received, and receiving it diminishes it. The diminishment is the point, and it is the most precise visual definition of non-extractive love in contemporary art.

Doris Salcedo (b. 1958)

Furniture embedded in concrete; rose petals in a plaza floor; chairs suspended on a facade

Political grief held without monumentalising it and without asking anything of the viewer in return. Refusing the monument is an ethical move that is also a compositional one, which is the part that transfers to a studio.

Work that refuses to be resolved

The wound present rather than explained, and the question held open.

Frida Kahlo (1907–1954)

The Broken Column (1944)

The spine as a crumbling pillar, the body pierced by nails, a medical corset. Made from the darkest place and transformed, through the absolute refusal of comfort, into something that has accompanied millions of people in their own darkness. The wound is not the enemy of the work. It is its ground.

Hannah Wilke (1940–1993)

The chewing-gum body casts; the late self-portraits

Her own flesh as medium, photographed across decades from seductive to ravaged, documenting her cancer treatment without flinching. The body's full story told by the body itself rather than translated into something more comfortable to receive.

Wolfgang Tillmans (b. 1968)

The darkroom abstractions

Images made without a camera, by exposing light-sensitive paper to light directly. What looks like damage is the record of a direct encounter between light and surface. Removing the apparatus is available in graphite too: a line made with no intention to depict is the same move.

Yayoi Kusama (b. 1929)

Dots, nets and the infinity rooms; seven decades

Obsessive accumulation as the method by which an overwhelming inner state is metabolised. Living voluntarily in a psychiatric institution since 1977 and going to the studio every day. The work is made from the disturbance rather than in spite of it, and the daily attendance is what makes the material usable.

Work that refuses to be looked past

The body marked by exclusion, taking the full frame.

Zanele Muholi (b. 1972)

Faces and Phases; Somnyama Ngonyama

Over five hundred portraits of Black lesbian and trans South Africans, and a self-portrait series in which the photographed body takes the whole frame without apology. Rupture by systemic violence turned into sovereignty rather than into evidence. The full-frame decision is the argument.

Firelei Báez (b. 1981)

Figures merging with historical documents and colonial cartography

The body of the historically erased is also the body in mystical encounter. For the colonised subject the via negativa is the condition of survival made luminous rather than a practice chosen. Painting onto the archival document makes the argument structurally instead of by depiction.

Kudzanai-Violet Hwami (b. 1993)

Large-scale paintings; figures fragmented and reconstructed

The wound as generative, held as a queer Zimbabwean visual practice. The body marked by exclusion has been given, by that marking, a particular quality of vision. Fragmentation used as construction rather than as damage.

Kara Walker (b. 1969)

The cut-paper silhouettes

Unmetabolised histories of racial violence made present in the room. The work does what the nervous system does with unprocessed trauma: stores it in image and returns it as sensation in the viewer's body.

Work that refuses the gap between inner and outer

Devotion and transformation as one continuous act.

Diego Rivera (1886–1957)

Detroit Industry Murals (1932–33)

Workers' bodies, industrial process, scientific research and the cycles of the earth held in one twenty-seven-panel work. The engaged path is not separate from beauty, from mysticism, from the daily or from the body, and the murals make that argument at architectural scale without apology.

Lauren Halsey (b. 1987)

Carved hieroglyph columns; community structures; South Central archives

Inner devotion and outer transformation as one act. The studio is in the neighbourhood and the work insists those two facts are inseparable. A practice rooted in a place rather than shipped from one.

Tau Lewis (b. 1993)

Hand-sewn figures from reclaimed leather, fabric and hair

Trauma metabolized understood as literal stitching: broken material made whole through sustained manual attention. Toronto-based, of Jamaican and Trinidadian heritage. The nearest artist on the list geographically and among the closest in method.

Sonya Clark (b. 1967)

Unraveling

A Confederate flag unravelled one thread at a time in public, with passersby invited to take part. What it costs to undo a violent inheritance, thread by thread. The difficulty of the process is the work's argument.

Practices that show a route

Held for how the working life was built rather than for the work alone. None of these four built a career through an e-commerce funnel.

Jean Smith

11 × 14 inch portraits, \$100 USD, since 2016

More than fifteen hundred sold, mostly within minutes of posting, in named series to repeat collectors. Left the day job; surplus income directed toward founding a free artist residency. Priced for access as an explicitly political choice. What does not transfer: thirty-five years of standing through Mecca Normal, and fifteen-hour days at peak. What does: the fixed format, which removes every pricing decision.

Caitlin Winner

Weekend painting alongside a career in technology

A visible arc from roughly 2021 to 2025: juried shows, a fund, a residency, press, then representation. The order is the lesson. Shows and grants first, press after, representation after that, teaching on top of the credibility rather than instead of it.

Zoey Frank

Roughly one online course a year, \$185 to \$350

Taught live, recorded the same day, then sold as an evergreen recording. Gallery representation, grants and international prizes underneath it. Teaching as the income layer that follows reputation. The model the Foundations plan is built against.

Flora Yukhnovich

MA 2017; seven-figure auction sales within four years

Found on Instagram by a dealer. Held here as the route that cannot be planned for and should not be treated as impossible either. What transfers is a singular visual language with real art-historical grounding, which is built rather than discovered.

Writing

One entry, and the standard the rest of the writing is measured against.

Maria Popova

The Marginalian

The mentor for the writing, and what is borrowed is a relationship rather than a style. Popova writes from inside a question she has not finished with, holds several thinkers in the same room and lets them disagree, and trusts the reader to follow without being managed. Intimacy with the question is the standard. Where a Dear Ordinary post goes thin, it is usually because it started explaining instead of staying inside the question.

Shunryu Suzuki (1904–1971)

Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind

In the beginner's mind there are many possibilities; in the expert's mind there are few. The condition the whole project runs on, and the reason it stays inviting: people can feel when someone is seeking alongside them rather than delivering from above.

HOW THIS LIST IS MAINTAINED

Entries are added when a work changes something in the studio rather than when it is admired. That is a higher bar and it keeps the list short enough to be read rather than filed.

Every claim about an artist's reception has to be one that can be documented with named critics or named positions. Where it cannot, the tension is described in the work itself rather than in the reception, because a work can hold a question without a critical controversy being attached to it.

Citations are checked character by character against the actual source. AI tools reliably produce confident, plausible and wrong citation details, including titles, years, journals and publishers, and a citation carried forward from a draft without checking is the failure most likely to reach print.

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